MOREH NEVUCHIM

Why Rambam Wrote the Guide

Given Tuesday 21 April 2026 · The Rambam's Introduction to Moreh Nevuchim, Part 1

Sefer: מורה נבוכים / Moreh Nebuchim — The Guide for the Perplexed **Author:** רבינו משה בן מימון — Rambam (Maimonides) **Section:** Introductory Letter to Rabbi Yosef + Beginning of the Introduction **Text:** Sefaria (modern Hebrew translation from Arabic, likely Prof. Schwartz)

Preliminary Notes

- **Which text are we using?** Sefaria has a modern Hebrew translation from the Arabic — not the Rambam's original words, but a translation. Rav Kapach's translation with footnotes is the primary study text for preparation.
- **Important:** The Moreh is not really a "book" — Rambam never calls it that. He wrote essays/chapters and sent them to his student. They were later compiled into what we call the Moreh.
- **The headlines (rashei perakim) on Sefaria** are NOT from the Rambam — they're modern editorial summaries. Same for bracketed text.

The Introductory Letter: Why Rambam Wrote This

Opening — בשם ה' אל עולם

- Rambam opens with the pasuk from the end of Parashat Vayera: ויטע אשל בבאר שבע ויקרא שם בשם ה' אל עולם
- Avraham = the father of monotheism, proclaiming the unity of Hashem to the world
- Rambam is saying: I am continuing this mission — proclaiming the yichud Hashem

The Student: Rabbi Yosef ben Rabbi Yehuda

- Rambam addresses his student Rabbi Yosef ben Yehuda ibn Shimon
- We know: he was a member of the Beit Din in Egypt for a period, died in 1226
- He came from far away to study under the Rambam in Egypt

The Progression — How Rambam Assessed His Student

Before meeting in person:

- Rabbi Yosef sent letters, poetry, and prose from Alexandria
- Rambam was impressed but cautious: שמא תשוקתו גדולה מהשגתו — "Perhaps his desire is greater than his reach"

After meeting:

- Rambam guided him in astronomy → saw he already had a basis
- Sent him to study more **mathematics** (prerequisite for astronomy)

- Then more **astronomy**
- Then **logic**
- Only THEN: felt it appropriate to reveal the secrets of the Nevi'im

The Hierarchy of Study

There's a clear order the Rambam insists on:

1. **Mathematics** (foundation)
2. **Astronomy** (builds on maths)
3. **Logic** (the discipline of reasoning)
4. **Secrets of Torah / Theology** (only after all the above)

Imagine today: Going to a rav to study theology and he says "First, go study some more maths and science. Then come back to me." That's what the Rambam did.

The Mutakallimun (Kalam Philosophers)

- Rabbi Yosef asked Rambam to explain the **Mutakallimun** — Islamic philosophers
- Kalam (كلام) = "words" in Arabic (the school of Islamic philosophy)
- They tried to reconcile Greek philosophy with Islamic theology (8th–9th centuries onward)
- **Saadia Gaon** relied heavily on the Mutakallimun in Emunot VeDeot
- **Rambam** generally didn't like them — felt they were too apologetic
- Rav Kapach thinks when Rambam says "you learned from others," he's referring to Saadia Gaon

The Catalyst — Why He Actually Wrote It

וכאשר גזר האל את פרידתנו... עוררוני הפגישות הללו

- When Rabbi Yosef had to leave → Rambam felt a **lack**
- The time they spent studying together had aroused something in him
- He had thought about writing these things before but never got round to it
- Now that his student was gone → he felt compelled to continue teaching through writing

הניע אותי חסרונך לחבר את החיבור הזה

- "Your absence motivated me to compose this work"
- Wrote in chapters/essays → sent them one by one to Rabbi Yosef

The Teacher-Student Dynamic

- The Gemara: יותר ממה שהעגל רוצה לינוק הפרה רוצה להניק — "More than the calf wants to suck, the cow wants to nurse"
- Pirkei Avot: מתלמידי יותר מכולם — "From my students I learned the most"
- Teaching satisfies the teacher — when the student left, the Rambam felt a void → that void became the Moreh

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The Rambam's Introduction — Purpose of the Moreh

Three Opening Verses

1. **Tehillim:** הודיעני דרך זו אלך כי אליך נשאתי נפשי — "Show me the path, Hashem — I look to You for guidance"
2. **Mishlei:** אליכם אישים אקרא וקולי אל בני אדם — "To you men (ishim) I call, and my voice to humans (bnei adam)"
3. **Mishlei:** הט אזנך ושמע דברי חכמים ולבך תשית לדעתי — "Listen to the sages, but put your heart to MY knowledge"

Why these three?

- Verse 1: General — guide me on the path
- Verse 2 (Efodi's explanation): The Moreh has **multiple levels of meaning**

  אישים = the elect, the wise → will understand deeper levels

  בני אדם = regular people → will understand the surface level
- Same text, different depths of understanding
- Verse 3 (Rav Kapach): Rambam will quote many philosophers and sages throughout
- Listen to them all — BUT: ולבך תשית לדעתי — at the end of the day, follow MY view

Purpose 1: Explaining Terms in Tanach

מטרתו הראשונה של חיבור זה היא ביאור משמעויות של מונחים המופיעים בספרי הנבואה

Three categories of terms that cause confusion:

Category 1: Multi-meaning terms (מונחים רב-משמעיים)

- One Hebrew word with multiple meanings in different contexts
- Example: **חי** (chai) — can mean "live," "raw," or when applied to Hashem (חי ה') → neither alive nor dead, something beyond
- Example: **קרן** (keren) — can mean "horn" or "ray" (as in קרן עור פניו)
- Simple people understand only ONE meaning → miss the deeper layers

Category 2: Borrowed/metaphorical terms (מושאלים)

- Words used metaphorically — people take them literally
- Classic example: **עיני ה'** (the eyes of Hashem) — doesn't mean literal eyes with pupils → means hashgachah (divine oversight/attention)
- This is the core of **anti-anthropomorphism** — a major theme of the entire Moreh
- Rambam will later write (end of Part 1): believing in a corporeal God is **worse than serving avodah zarah**
- During his lifetime, many people — even rabbis — believed God had some kind of physicality

Category 3: Ambiguous terms (מסופקים)

- Sometimes borrowed, sometimes multi-meaning — unclear which
- Context determines the correct understanding

Who Is This Book For?

אין מטרתו של חיבור זה להסביר את כולם להמון

NOT for:

- The masses / simple people
- Beginners in study
- Even great Talmidei Chachamim who only know the **legal** aspects of Torah (halacha, Gemara, dayanut) but nothing beyond

Written FOR a person who has ALL of the following:

1. **Religious** — observant, committed to Torah
2. **Clear belief** in the truth and veracity of Torah
3. **Completed their character** — good middot, wholesome personality
4. **Studied philosophy** — understands philosophical terminology and concepts
5. **Has intellectual curiosity** — naturally drawn to understand more
6. **But is PERPLEXED** — reads verses in Tanach that seem to contradict what they've studied philosophically

The Perplexed Person's Dilemma

Such a person faces two terrible options:

Option A: Follow their intellect → throw away their Torah beliefs → think they've abandoned the foundations of faith

Option B: Stick with their simple Torah understanding → suppress their intellectual curiosity → constantly troubled, walking a tightrope

ויהיה שרוי תמיד בכאב לב ובמבוכה גדולה

- Either way → constant pain and great confusion
- The Moreh is written to rescue this person from the dilemma

Purpose 2: Explaining Veiled Imagery in Tanach

ביאור משלים חבויים מאוד הכתובים בספרי נביאים

- Some passages in Tanach use imagery/analogy/parable — but it's **not obvious** that they're imagery
- Simple people read them at face value and think there's nothing deeper
- Even wise people who read them at surface level → become confused
- When the deeper meaning is explained → the confusion is resolved
- **This is why it's called "The Guide for the Perplexed"**

What This Book Will NOT Do

אין אני אומר שחיבור זה פותר כל קשייה

- Won't solve ALL your difficulties — but will solve most of them and the hardest ones
- Won't treat any topic exhaustively — even in person that would be impossible, all the more so in writing
- Won't explain every image/parable to its deepest level

Why Not Exhaustive? Two Reasons

Reason 1: These are matters of Ma'aseh Bereishit (physics/cosmology) and Ma'aseh Merkavah (theology/metaphysics)

- The Gemara says: don't teach Ma'aseh Bereishit to two people, don't teach Ma'aseh Merkavah even to one — unless he's wise, and even then only rashei perakim (headlines/rubrics)
- Therefore: אל תבקש ממני יותר מראשי פרקים — "Don't expect more than general guidelines"

Reason 2: Deliberately not systematic

אפילו התחלות אלו אינן מסודרות... אלא מפוזרות ומעורבות

- Rambam **purposefully** scattered and mixed the ideas throughout the book
- He wants the truth to **shine through** but also to **disappear again**
- He doesn't want to go against Hashem's intent: סוד ה' ליראיו — the secrets are for those who fear Hashem

The Bombshell About Bereishit

דע שגם בדברים הטבעיים אין ללמוד בפירוש

- Even matters of **physics** — the Torah doesn't state them plainly
- Even the Chachamim spoke about them in riddles and parables
- **Implication:** The first chapter of Bereishit = Ma'aseh Bereishit = cosmology/physics
- Rambam is saying: **Bereishit is not to be understood at face value** — it's analogy, it's imagery for something deeper
- Physics is a prerequisite for theology → both have secrets → both are expressed through imagery in Torah

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The Lightning Analogy — Levels of Understanding

לעתים האמת מציצה לנו כך שאנו חושבים אותה ליום ושוב... לחזור ולהיבלע לחושך

- Humans grope in darkness in matters of physics and metaphysics
- Sometimes we get a streak of light → then darkness returns

The Spectrum

Level	Description	Example
Constant lightning — night becomes day	The highest prophet	**Moshe Rabbeinu** — ואתה פה עמוד עמדי / קרן עור פניו
Regular flashes throughout the night	The regular prophets	Yeshayahu, Yechezkel, etc.
One flash in entire lifetime	Minimal prophetic experience	Eldad & Medad — ויתנבאו ולא יספו (prophesied once, never again)
No lightning — but occasional sparks from rubbing stones	No prophecy, but intellectual illumination	Most of us at best — flashes that come and go, כלהט החרב המתהפכת
Complete darkness — groping in the night	No light at all, ever	The masses — לא ידעו ולא יבינו בחשכה יתהלכו

Key Points About the Analogy

- **Prophecy is not constant** — even prophets don't always experience it
- They "tune in": והיה כנגן המנגן — they would use music to enter the right state
- Some prophets experienced more visions than others (did Yechezkel have more than Yeshayahu? We don't know)
- **For us without prophecy:** the best we can hope for is occasional intellectual shining — how much depends on our own development
- **Rambam's key message:** The more you develop your intellect AND your character → the more light you'll receive from this book

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Yom Ha'atzmaut Thought

Magdil vs. Migdol in Birkat HaMazon

- Weekdays: ישועות מלכו **מגדיל** (from Tehillim) — active, Hif'il → you are CAUSING salvation, bringing it about
- Shabbat: ישועות מלכו **מגדול** (from Shmuel) — completed tower → everything is whole, the redemption is complete
- **Weekdays** = ששת ימים תעשה — we work, we build, we bring about yeshuah. We are in magdil mode.
- **Shabbat** = כאילו כל מלאכתך עשויה — we exist, we BE, everything feels complete. We are in migdol mode.
- **The prayer:** that Eretz Yisrael will go from magdil (building, working) to migdol (the completed tower)

Rav Kook — Why Rabbi Abba Kissed the Stones

- Gemara (Ketubot): Rabbi Abba would kiss the stones and dust of Eretz Yisrael when arriving
- Rav Kook: why specifically stones? Not the earth?
- If he kissed the earth → you'd think it's because of mitzvot ha-teluyot ba'aretz (agricultural mitzvot)
- Stones have no growth, no agricultural mitzvot → he kissed them for the **intrinsic kedushah** of the land itself

Rav Reines — Ben Tzion

- The Chida: if a woman's children are dying in infancy → name the next child **Ben Tzion** for protection
- Rav Reines' metaphorical interpretation:
- "Children dying" = people dying spiritually, losing faith, losing connection to Torah
- "Call them Ben Tzion" = give them a love of Tzion, a love of Israel
- Because if they love Israel → subconsciously they believe in Torah (the promised land = Torah's promise)
- Eretz Yisrael can be the anchor that brings people back

Key Takeaways

1. The Moreh was written because **Rambam's student left** → the void of not teaching drove him to write.
2. **Prerequisites for understanding the Moreh:** maths → astronomy → logic → then theology.
3. **Purpose 1:** Explain multi-meaning, metaphorical, and ambiguous terms in Tanach.
4. **Purpose 2:** Explain veiled imagery in Tanach that isn't obviously metaphorical.
5. **Written for:** Religious, philosophically educated people who are perplexed between Torah and philosophy.
6. **Won't be exhaustive** — only rashei perakim (headlines). Deliberately scattered, not systematic.
7. **Bereishit is not to be read at face value** — it's Ma'aseh Bereishit expressed through imagery.
8. **Lightning analogy:** Different people receive different amounts of intellectual/prophetic light — from Moshe's constant illumination to complete darkness. Our level depends on our own development.

Next Class

- Continuing the Rambam's Introduction — his advice on how to study this book, and the second part of the introduction

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Yom Ha'atzmaut Sameach — Chag Sameach

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